

Teacher Guide — primary / module-08-yoga

IKS Curriculum

Table of Contents

Overview

Module 8 — Yoga for Little Ones

Age band: Primary · **Grades:** 3–5 · **Duration:** 10 sessions × 30 min (with ~12 min movement)

What children will learn

1. Five safe yoga poses: tree, mountain, child’s rest, cat-cow, bumblebee.
2. The Sanskrit words *yoga*, *āsana*, *prāṇa*.
3. How to breathe slowly and count breaths.
4. That moving and breathing together makes the body feel calm or excited.
5. To invent and name their own yoga pose.

How this module sounds

- Lots of movement. Animal sounds. Giggles allowed.
- One Sanskrit word per day, repeated as a chant.
- Eyes closed only if children are comfortable; eyes-lowered is fine.

NEP 2020 alignment

- §4.6 — Indian Knowledge Systems
- §4.31 — Physical fitness, well-being
- §1.4 — Foundational holistic learning

Materials

- One mat (or clean floor square) per child
- Comfortable clothing
- Wall picture of the 5 poses (with animal cues)

Safety floor — non-negotiable

- **No** Sūrya Namaskāra at this band (too complex).
- **No** inversions, no backbends beyond gentle cat-cow.

- **No** breath retention. Natural breath only.
- **No** competitive holding.
- **Always** an opt-out: child can sit out any pose, no questions.

Day-by-day

Day	Title	Focus
1	What is Yoga?	Story + tādāsana (mountain)
2	The Tree (vṛkṣāsana)	Standing balance, animal cue (flamingo)
3	Rest like a Child (balāsana)	Calming pose
4	Cat-Cow	Spine wave + breath
5	Bumblebee Breath (bhrāmarī)	Humming breath
6	Animal Yoga Walk	All five poses in a flow
7	Invent a Pose	Each child creates one
8	Project Day 1	Design & name your pose
9	Project Day 2	Practise teaching it
10	Pose Showcase	Each child teaches their pose

Project

Each child invents ONE yoga pose, gives it a Sanskrit-sounding name, and teaches the class for 1 minute on Day 10.

See [assessments/project-brief.md](#).

Source

Patañjali's Yoga Sūtras + traditional Indian yoga practice. For older-grade depth, see Middle-band Module 8.

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 8 (Primary) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance (30-min sessions)

Day	Title	Pose / Practice	Animal cue
1	What is Yoga?	tādāsana	mountain

Day	Title	Pose / Practice	Animal cue
2	The Tree	vṛkṣāsana	flamingo
3	Child's Rest	balāsana	sleeping puppy
4	Cat-Cow	mārjārī- bīdalāsana	cat + cow
5	Bumblebee Breath	bhrāmarī	buzzing bee
6	Animal Yoga Walk	All 5 in a flow	—
7	Invent a Pose	Creative time	child's own
8	Project Day 1	Design + name	—
9	Project Day 2	Practise teaching	—
10	Pose Showcase	Teach your pose	—

Daily structure (30 min)

Time	What
3 min	Settle on mat, 5 breaths
5 min	Story / new pose introduction
12 min	Practice
5 min	Reflection / animal sounds / fun
5 min	Tādāsana close + namaste

What children leave with

- 5 safe poses they can do daily at home.
- Sanskrit words *yoga*, *āsana*, *prāṇa* — recognised, not memorised.
- Bumblebee breath as a calming tool.
- One invented pose with a name.
- The habit of starting and ending with the mountain.

Teacher Notes

Teacher Notes — Module 8 Yoga (Primary)

Tone

Movement is play. Yoga at this age should feel like fun, not like a class. Animal cues turn poses into games.

Safety — please read before Day 1

- **NEVER** inversions (headstand, plough, downward-dog beyond a hint).
- **NEVER** backbends beyond gentle cat (mild arch).
- **NEVER** breath retention or forceful breathing.
- **NEVER** correct alignment with your hands without explicit child consent.
- **Opt-out always allowed.** Child can sit in sukhāsana (cross-legged seat) and watch.

Medical opt-outs

Collect before Day 1. Common conditions: - Asthma — restrict bhrāmarī (Day 5) — natural breathing only. - Knee/ankle injury — modify standing balance poses (Day 2 — sit instead). - Any back issue — skip cat-cow’s arch (Day 4).

On the Sanskrit names

- Use the names once a day, slowly. Don’t quiz children on them.
- Pair each name with the animal cue — “tree pose, like a flamingo standing on one leg” — and the animal cue is what they’ll remember.

Common things to handle

1. **A child can’t balance in vr̥kṣāsana.** Use a wall. Or hold a friend’s hand.
2. **A child won’t try the cat sound in cat-cow.** No pressure. Movement only.
3. **A child is anxious to close eyes.** Eyes-lowered or eyes-open is fine.
4. **A child says “this is silly.”** Validate. *“Yes, it’s a little silly. That’s part of the fun. You can sit out if you’d rather just watch.”*

Project oversight

- Days 8–10: each child invents ONE pose, gives it a name, and teaches it for 1 minute on Day 10.
- Pose must be SAFE (no inversions, no jumping). Teacher vets all invented poses on Day 8.
- Names can be anything — Sanskrit-sounding, animal names, made-up words.

If you only have 6 days

- Day 1: Mountain + tree
- Day 2: Child’s rest + cat-cow
- Day 3: Bumblebee breath
- Day 4: Animal walk
- Day 5: Invent a pose
- Day 6: Showcase

Sources

Sources — Module 8 Yoga (Primary)

Teacher reference only.

Source for the poses

- Standard primary-school yoga curricula (e.g. Yoga Alliance children’s programmes).
- The five chosen poses are the safest, most accessible for Grade 3–5.

Source for the Sanskrit names + framework

- Patañjali, *Yoga Sūtras* (c. 2nd c. BCE – 4th c. CE) — the eight-limbed framework.
- For deeper background see the Middle-band Module 8 .rag-cache/ and sources.md.

For families who ask

- We teach yoga as physical practice with attention to breath. Religious framing is honoured but not centred.
- For deeper exploration of yoga’s philosophy, see the Middle-band module.

Day 1 — What is Yoga? (The Mountain)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children meet yoga through a story and stand in *tāḍāsana* (mountain pose).

Materials

- Mats / floor space
- A picture of a mountain

The flow

Settle (3 min)

Sit on mat, hands on knees. 5 natural breaths.

Story (5 min)

*“Yoga is a very old practice from India. It uses our bodies, our breath, and our mind — all together. The Sanskrit word **yoga** means ‘to join.’ We join body, breath, and mind.”*

*“Today our pose is **tāḍāsana** — mountain pose. We stand still and tall, like a mountain.”*

Tāḍāsana practice (12 min)

- Show the picture of a mountain. “*What’s a mountain like?*” (Tall. Strong. Still.)
- “*Now BE a mountain.*”
- Stand at top of mat. Feet hip-width.
- “*Press your feet into the ground like roots.*”
- “*Stand TALL. Pretend a string is gently pulling the top of your head up.*”
- “*Take 3 deep breaths. Breathe like a calm mountain.*”

Hold for 30 sec. Release. Repeat 3 times.

Between rounds, ask: - “*Did anyone feel taller?*” - “*Did your feet feel heavier or lighter?*”

Reflection (5 min)

- “*Why might mountains be the first pose we learn?*” (Steady. Strong. Doesn’t move.)
- “*You’re a mountain. You can come back to mountain anytime you need to feel steady.*”

Close (5 min)

Tāḍāsana one more time. Then sit. Hands together at heart. “*Namaste*” — “*I bow to you.*”

Homework

- Stand like a mountain for 30 seconds before brushing your teeth tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Hold for 60 seconds. Add “soft eyes looking ahead.”
- **Tier down:** Hold for 15 seconds. Lean on a wall if needed.

Teacher’s quick notes

- This is the foundational pose for the whole module. Use it to open and close every class.
- Some children will fidget. Allow gentle sway — mountains in nature aren’t perfectly still either.

Day 2 — The Tree (vṛkṣāsana)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children try the tree pose. Wobble is welcome.

Materials

- Mats
- Picture of a tree (and a flamingo)

The flow

Settle + opening tādāsana (3 min)

5 breaths, then 30 sec mountain pose.

Story (5 min)

*“Today’s pose is **vrkṣāsana** — tree pose. A tree stands tall on one root. Today YOU’ll stand tall on one foot.”*

“Trees sway a little. So will you. That’s totally OK.”

Tree practice (15 min)

- *“Start in mountain. Move your weight onto your **LEFT** foot.”*
- *“Now bend your **RIGHT** knee. Put the **SOLE** of your right foot against the **INSIDE** of your **LEFT** calf. Or below the knee. **NOT** on the knee.”*
- *“Hands at heart — palms together. Or raise them like branches over your head.”*
- *“Look at one spot on the wall and keep looking at it.”*
- *“Breathe like a calm tree.”*
- Hold 15 sec. Switch sides. Hold 15 sec.
- Repeat 3 times each side.

If children wobble: *“Trees sway in the wind! Wobble is what balance feels like when it’s learning.”*

If children fall: laugh together. *“Try again.”*

Reflection (4 min)

- *“Which side was easier?”*
- *“What did your eyes look at?”*

Close (3 min)

Tādāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- Stand on one leg at home for 10 seconds. Switch. Repeat. (Brush teeth while doing it!)

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Hold for 30 sec. Try with eyes closed (briefly).
- **Tier down:** Use a wall behind you for support. Or rest the lifted foot on the floor next to the standing foot.

Teacher's quick notes

- THE knee safety cue is critical. Foot above OR below the knee. NEVER ON the side of the knee.
- Wobble is information. Falling is information. Both are fine. The skill is *trying again*.

Day 3 — Rest Like a Child (balāsana)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children rest in *balāsana* (child's pose) and notice how it feels in the body.

Materials

- Mats
- Optional: soft blanket for each child

The flow

Settle + opening *tāḍāsana* (3 min)

Story (3 min)

*"Today's pose is **balāsana** — child's pose. The name literally means 'child posture.' It's the way babies sometimes sleep — curled up, safe, resting."*

"This is a REST pose. Not a hard pose."

Child's pose practice (15 min)

- *"Kneel on your mat. Knees wide apart. Big toes touching."*
- *"Fold forward. Bring your forehead toward the mat. (If it doesn't reach — stack your fists and put your head on them.)"*
- *"Arms forward or alongside your body — whichever feels nice."*
- *"Breathe slowly. This is rest."*

Hold for 60 seconds. *"Notice your breath."*

Come up slowly. *"Did anything in your body feel different?"*

Repeat 2 more times (with brief activity between — try a different arm position each time).

Bumblebee preview (5 min)

Sit cross-legged. *"Tomorrow we'll do a special breath called bumblebee. Just to start: hum like a bee for 3 seconds. Mmmmmm. Did you feel the buzz?"*

Reflection (2 min)

- “Was child’s pose more like resting or more like working?”
- “What did you notice when you sat back up?”

Close (2 min)

Tāḍāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- When you feel tired tonight, try child’s pose for 1 minute before bed.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Stay in child’s pose for 2 minutes. Count your breaths.
- **Tier down:** If knees hurt, put a folded blanket between calves and thighs.

Teacher’s quick notes

- Child’s pose is restorative. Don’t rush.
- If a child’s forehead doesn’t reach the mat (hip flexibility), stacked fists work fine.
- This is also THE pose to offer when a child is overwhelmed mid-class.

Day 4 — Cat and Cow (mārjārī-bidalāsana)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children do the cat-cow spine wave with breath co-ordination.

Materials

- Mats
- Pictures of a cat (arched back) and a cow (sagging back)

The flow

Settle + opening tāḍāsana (3 min)

Story (5 min)

“Today we have *TWO* poses that go together — **mārjārī** (cat) and **bidalāsana** (cow). We flow between them like waves.”

Show pictures: cat with arched back, cow with belly down.

Cat-cow practice (15 min)

- “Come to your hands and knees on your mat. Hands under shoulders, knees under hips.”

- “COW: as you BREATHE IN, drop your belly. Lift your head and tailbone. Look slightly up. Moooo if you like.”
- “CAT: as you BREATHE OUT, round your back like a scared cat. Tuck your chin. Meow!”
- “COW (inhale). CAT (exhale). COW. CAT.”

Do 5 slow rounds. Then 5 more, focusing on the breath.

Animal sound bonus (4 min)

“Animal sounds are allowed. Cows say ‘moo.’ Cats say ‘meow.’ Try making the sound on each pose.”

Reflection (3 min)

- “Which felt better — cat or cow?”
- “Did the breath help you move?”

Close (close)

Tāḍāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- 5 cat-cow waves before breakfast. Make the sounds!

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** 10 rounds with deeper breathing.
- **Tier down:** Skip the sounds if shy. Just the movement.

Teacher’s quick notes

- The breath-movement co-ordination is the actual skill. Cue: “breath leads, body follows.”
- Watch wrists — students with wrist issues can do this on forearms.
- Some children will giggle uncontrollably at the animal sounds. Let them — it loosens the body.

Day 5 — Bumblebee Breath (bhrāmarī)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children practise *bhrāmarī* — the humming breath — and notice the buzzing sensation.

Materials

- Mats
- (No props needed — just bodies and voices)

The flow

Settle + opening tādāsana (3 min)

Story (5 min)

*“Today’s special practice is a **breath**, not a pose. It’s called **bhrāmarī** — bumblebee breath. We hum like bees.”*

“Why bees? Because the humming feels like a buzzing in your head — it helps the mind feel quiet.”

Bhrāmarī practice (15 min)

- *“Sit cross-legged. Hands on your knees. Back tall.”*
- *“Take a slow breath IN.”*
- *“As you breathe OUT, hum. ‘Mmmmmmmmm.’ For as long as you can.”*
- *“Then breathe in again. Then hum again.”*

Do 5 rounds together.

Then try ONE round with hands gently covering the ears (just close the ear flaps with fingers).
“Now your hum sounds extra loud — like bees inside your head!”

Do 3 rounds with ears covered.

Reflection (5 min)

- *“How did your head feel after the buzzing?”*
- *“Was it easier or harder than counting breaths?”*

Close (2 min)

Tādāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- 5 bumblebee breaths before bedtime tonight. Notice how you feel.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Try 10 rounds. Try a deeper hum.
- **Tier down:** Just normal slow breathing if humming feels uncomfortable.

Teacher’s quick notes

- Asthma alert — if a child has asthma, they do natural breath, no bhrāmarī.
- The “buzzing in the head” is a real sensation — vibration calms the nervous system.
- Some children won’t want to make sound in front of others. They can hum very quietly or just exhale slowly.

Day 6 — Animal Yoga Walk

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Children flow through all 5 poses + bhrāmarī as a sequence, animal-style.

Materials

- Mats / open floor

The flow

Settle + opening tādāsana (3 min)

Demo the sequence (5 min)

- “Today we put *EVERYTHING* together. The Animal Yoga Walk.”
- “Mountain → Flamingo (Tree, both sides) → Sleeping Puppy (Child’s pose) → Cat-Cow waves → Bumblebee → back to Mountain.”

Practice the flow (18 min)

Round 1: very slow, teacher calling each pose.

Mountain – 20 sec
Flamingo (tree pose, right) – 15 sec
Flamingo (tree pose, left) – 15 sec
Sleeping Puppy (child's pose) – 60 sec
Cat-Cow – 5 waves
Bumblebee Breath – 3 rounds
Mountain – 20 sec

Total: about 4 min per round.

Round 2: slightly faster, children leading themselves.

Optional Round 3: a brave child volunteers to call out the sequence.

Reflection (3 min)

- “Which animal felt best in your body?”
- “Which one was hardest?”

Close (1 min)

Tādāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- Practice the full sequence at home — your favourite part TWICE.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Add 5 more cat-cow rounds OR 5 more bumblebee breaths.
- **Tier down:** Skip the bumblebee if shy or unwell. Replace with 3 natural breaths in seated.

Teacher's quick notes

- This is the practice rehearsal for the project. Children should know the FLOW now.
- Day 7 they'll INVENT a pose to add — preview it: “tomorrow, you'll make UP a pose and give it a name!”

Day 7 — Invent a Pose

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Each child invents ONE pose, gives it a name, and tries it.

Materials

- Mats
- Drawing paper + crayons (to draw the pose)

The flow

Settle + opening tādāsana (3 min)

Story (5 min)

“Yoga has thousands of poses, and people are still inventing new ones today. Today YOU invent ONE.”

“It can be inspired by an animal, an object, a feeling — anything. The rules:”

- It must be SAFE (no jumping, no flips, no putting weight on your head).
- It must be HOLDABLE for 10 seconds.
- It must have a NAME (any name — Sanskrit-sounding, animal, made-up).

Invent time (15 min)

- Children sit on their mats and think.
- 5 minutes: try poses quietly.
- 5 minutes: draw your favourite invented pose on paper, with the name above.
- 5 minutes: try the pose 3 times.

Share (5 min)

- 2 brave volunteers demonstrate their invented pose for the class.

- Class tries it together for 5 seconds.

Close (2 min)

Tāḍāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- Practise your invented pose at home. Get a parent to try it!

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Invent TWO poses. Pick the better one for project day.
- **Tier down:** Modify an existing pose (e.g. tree pose but with hands at a different position).

Teacher's quick notes

- All poses must be vetted for safety. Walk around during invent time.
- Encourage creativity over imitation — but if a child copies tree pose with a different arm position, that's a creative achievement at this age.

Day 8 — Project Day 1

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Each child finalises their invented pose, draws it, and names it.

Materials

- Drawing paper + crayons
- Mats

The flow

Settle + opening tāḍāsana (3 min)

Project work (20 min)

- Each child decides their final pose name.
- Draws a clear picture of the pose.
- Writes: pose name, what part of the body it stretches/strengthens.
- Practises the pose 3 times.

Buddy check (5 min)

- Find a partner. Show your pose. Partner tries it. Partner says ONE thing that worked.

Close (2 min)

Tāḍāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- Practise teaching your pose to a parent at home. Get them to try it!

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Write 3 sentences of instructions for your pose.
- **Tier down:** Just a drawing + the name is enough.

Teacher's quick notes

- Confirm pose safety for every child. Redirect any unsafe poses now.
- Some children will struggle to invent — let them adapt an existing pose with a new name.

Day 9 — Project Day 2 (Practise Teaching)

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min

Goal

Each child rehearses their 1-minute pose teaching.

Materials

- Mats
- Pose drawings

The flow

Settle + opening tāḍāsana (3 min)

Rehearsal (20 min)

- Children pair up.
- Each child teaches their pose to their partner for 1 minute:
 - Name the pose.
 - Show the pose.
 - Give 2 cues (where to put hands, where to look, etc.).
 - Hold for 10 seconds.
- Swap.
- Then change partners and rehearse again. (Aim for 3 different partners.)

Wrap (5 min)

- 2 children share: “*What was the best feedback I got?*”

Close (2 min)

Tāḍāsana. Namaste.

Homework

- Practise your teaching ONE more time at home. Tomorrow is the showcase!

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Teach without your drawing — from memory.
- **Tier down:** Read off your drawing if you need to.

Teacher's quick notes

- The 1-minute teach is the actual project. Practice the timing.
- If a child is too shy to teach alone, they can co-teach with a buddy.

Day 10 — Pose Showcase

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Time:** 30 min (extend if needed)

Goal

Every child teaches their invented pose to the class for 1 minute.

Materials

- Mats laid out
- Stickers
- A bell / chime to mark 1 minute

The flow

Settle + opening tāḍāsana (3 min)

The biggest, most attentive mountain of the module.

Pose Showcase (24 min)

- 1 child at a time.
- 1 minute each (chime when time's up).
- Each child:
 1. Says their pose name.
 2. Shows the pose.
 3. Class tries it for 10 seconds.
- Class claps. Sticker.

With ~24 children in 24 minutes, plan tight pacing OR extend into a buffer period.

Closing ceremony (3 min)

- Whole class in tādāsana.
- Teacher: “You’ve all learned 5 poses, 1 breath, and INVENTED your own. You’re yoga teachers now.”
- Final namaste.

Homework

- None. Module complete.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** A child who finishes can lead the class in mountain pose during the closing.
- **Tier down:** Co-teach with a buddy if too shy alone.

Teacher’s quick notes

- This is celebration day. Every pose is a success.
- Take photos of every pose; send to parents.
- Mark the chime gently — children sometimes need 90 seconds, that’s fine.

Oral Recall — Module 8 Yoga (Primary)

No paper tests. Use these oral checks.

Day 3 — pose name recall

Class chorus: - “What’s the mountain pose called?” → **tādāsana** - “What’s the tree pose called?” → **vṛkṣāsana** - “What’s the child pose called?” → **balāsana**

Day 5 — breath check

- “What’s the bumblebee breath called?” → **bhrāmarī**
- “What’s the Sanskrit word for breath?” → **prāṇa**

Day 6 — animal walk completion

Each child completes one round = sticker.

Day 10 — showcase = automatic sticker

Every child who teaches their pose gets a sticker.

Optional match (Day 5 or 10)

Match the pose to the animal:

tādāsana	flamingo
vṛkṣāsana	sleeping puppy

balāsana	mountain
mārjārī	bee
bhrāmarī	cat

Hand back with sticker; no marks.

Activity 01 — The Animal Yoga Walk

Module: Yoga (Primary) · **Day:** 6 · **Time:** 18 min within Day 6's 30

Goal

Children flow through the 5 poses + bhrāmarī in sequence.

Materials

- Mats / floor space

Sequence (one round)

Time	Pose	Animal cue	Note
20 sec	Mountain (tāḍāsana)	-	Stand still and tall
15 sec	Tree right (vṛkṣāsana)	Flamingo	Foot on calf, not knee
15 sec	Tree left (vṛkṣāsana)	Flamingo	Switch sides
60 sec	Child's pose (balāsana)	Sleeping puppy	Forehead to mat
30 sec (5 waves)	Cat-Cow	Cat + cow	Breathe with each wave
30 sec (3 rounds)	Bumblebee	Bee	Hum on the exhale
20 sec	Mountain	-	Close

Total: about 3.5 min per round.

How to use

- Round 1: very slow, teacher calls each pose.
- Round 2: slightly faster, children lead themselves.
- Round 3 (optional): a brave child volunteer calls out.

Safety

- Vṛkṣāsana foot ABOVE or BELOW the standing knee, NEVER on it.
- Cat-cow: gentle. No deep backbend.

- Bhrāmarī: skip if asthma; replace with 3 natural breaths.

Clean-up

- Mats stacked.

Project Brief

Project — Module 8 Yoga (Primary)

What you'll make

Invent ONE yoga pose. Give it a name. Teach it to the class for 1 minute on Day 10.

Rules

- The pose must be SAFE — no jumping, no flips, no putting weight on your head.
- You must be able to HOLD the pose for 10 seconds.
- The name can be anything — Sanskrit-sounding, an animal, a feeling, a made-up word.

Schedule

- **Day 7:** invent + try.
- **Day 8:** draw + name.
- **Day 9:** practise teaching with a partner.
- **Day 10:** teach the class for 1 minute. Sticker!

What we'll celebrate

	What we celebrate
★	Your pose has a name
★★	You showed it clearly to the class
★★★	The class could try it along with you

All three stars = sticker + photo for parents.